



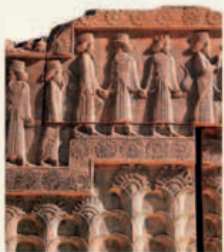
BEFORE

Alexander's conquests created an empire even larger than the Persian empire at its height. Anybody wishing to rule over it would have to take into account the legacy and traditions of Persia's Achaemenid rulers.

THE ACHAEMENID EMPIRE

The Achaemenid Empire << 92–93 reached its greatest extent under Darius I and his son Xerxes I in the 6th century BCE, and lost very little territory before Alexander << 96–97 began his conquest in 334 BCE.

Divided into **satrapies** (provinces governed by men appointed by the king), it had several royal capitals. The ceremonial capital of **Persepolis** was largely destroyed by Alexander, but its great stairways, decorated with reliefs of **subject rulers** bringing tribute, survive.



BAS-RELIEF OF SUBJECT RULERS, PERSEPOLIS

The Conquests of Alexander the Great

In just ten years, Alexander conquered the Persian Empire, the largest empire the world had ever seen. His own empire now stretched from North Africa and the eastern Mediterranean to the Indus valley in northern India. On his death in 323 BCE, his generals fought to decide who would inherit the largest share of the spoils.

KEY

- Empire and dependent regions of Alexander
- Route of Alexander the Great

The Greeks in Asia

The Achaemenid Persian Empire had ruled over an area extending from the Mediterranean to the Indus valley. It was all conquered by Alexander the Great in less than ten years, his army bringing with it ideas and tastes from Greek civilization that took root and flourished alongside local traditions.

Before his death, Alexander had placed the key provinces in the conquered Persian empire under the control of trusted governors. However, he allowed local systems of government, to which the people were

accustomed, to continue. Alexander appreciated the role of the Persians as an imperial people and, according to some accounts, tried to create a ruling race through intermarriage between his officers and Persian noblewomen.

The process of changing one mode of rule for another, he knew, was a delicate one and needed patience. He died in Babylon in 322 BCE (see p.97) before he realized his ambition of creating a completely unified empire

